# Barriers to Communication and some remedies

# What do you mean by Barrier?

- A barrier is defined as something that prevents or controls progress or movement. This definition implies that a barrier is something that comes in the way of the desired outcome.

- Communication is effective only if it creates the desired impact on the receiver.

# 5 steps to Overcome the barriers

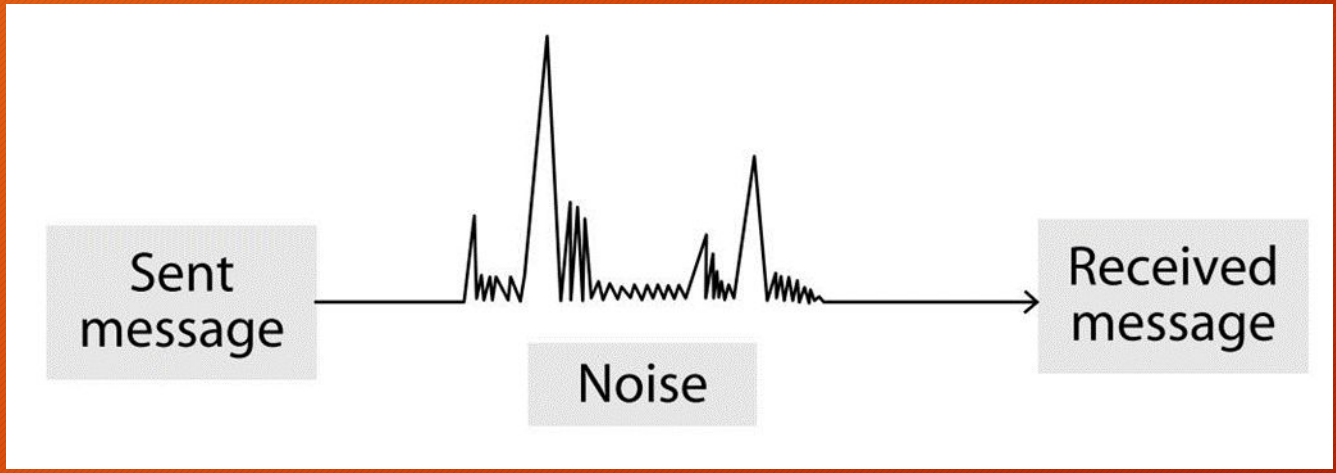
1. Identify the problem

E.g. (bimonthly report) not done,  for boss the term bimonthly meant twice in a month, whereas for subordinate it meant once in two months

2. Find the cause/barrier (choice of words)…..
3. Work on alternative solutions (avoid new difficulties)
4. opt for the best solution (twice a month, once a fortnight)
5. Follow up rigorously

# Noise

- Any interference in the message sent and the message received leads to the production of ‘noise’.
- The term communication barrier-an expansion of the concept of noise.
- Noise here does not mean sound, but a break or disturbance in the communication process.



# CLASSIFICATION OF NOISE

- 1. Channel noise: It is any interference in the mechanics of the medium used to send a message.
- Examples: Distortion due to faulty background, noise in telephone lines, or too high a volume or pitch from loudspeakers.
- 2. Semantic noise: It is generated internally, resulting from errors in the message itself. It may be because of the connotative (implied) meaning of a word that is interpreted differently by the sender and the receiver.
- Example: "condescend" (grace, dignity) might be intended positively but perceived negatively, reflecting assumed superiority. Other sources include unclear sentence structure, grammatical errors, misspellings, and punctuation mistakes.

# CLASSIFICATION OF BARRIERS

- To communicate smoothly and effectively in an organization, irrespective of your position, you need to know how barriers operate, why they cause misunderstandings, and how to minimize their negative impact.
- **Three types:**
- Intrapersonal
- Interpersonal
- Organizational

# 1. Intrapersonal Barriers

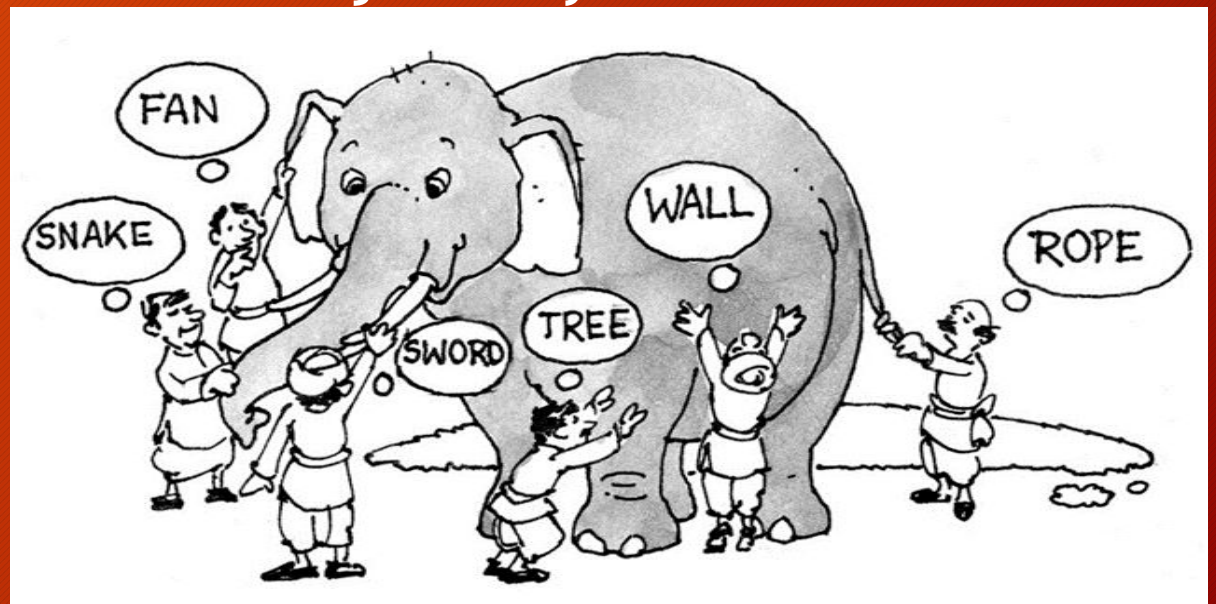
- Individual differences in perception, experience, and background create unique interpretations of information, leading to intrapersonal communication barriers.
- ***The common causes that lead to these intrapersonal barriers:***
- Wrong assumptions
- Varied perceptions
- Differing background
- Wrong inferences
- Blocked categories
- Categorical thinking

# WRONG ASSUMPTIONS

- A doctor advising a patient to take medicine "SOS" (i.e., during an emergency) without clarifying its meaning exemplifies this.
- Such errors stem from a lack of understanding of the receiver's background.
- To improve communication, try to see things from the listener's perspective, preventing these misunderstandings.

# VARIED PERCEPTIONS

- **Different individuals perceive the same situation uniquely, much like the blind men and the elephant.**
- Personal biases can cloud judgment, especially when favoring a particular individual.
- To overcome this, it's essential to maintain objectivity and consider all perspectives impartially.



# DIFFERING BACKGROUNDS

- **Diverse backgrounds influence message interpretation.**
- Differences in education, culture, and experience shape our understanding.
- For instance, a professor who has done rock-climbing might struggle to engage students unfamiliar with adventure sports.
- Tailoring messages to the audience's background is crucial.
- Empathy and understanding the listener's perspective are key to bridging these gaps.
- Careful word choice is essential due to multiple meanings and connotations, which can hinder effective communication

# WRONG INFERENCES

- **Fact-inference confusion** occurs when assumptions are made without concrete evidence.
- For example, assuming colleagues were laid off due to their absence during a recession is incorrect, as they were actually promoted. Inferences, should be supported by facts.
- Professionals in various fields must carefully distinguish between factual data and assumptions. Using qualifiers like "evidence suggests" or "in my opinion" clarifies that a statement is an inference rather than a confirmed fact.

# Blocked Categories

- Blocked categories are mental frameworks that restrict open-mindedness.
- People often resist information that contradicts their existing beliefs, values, or stereotypes. This resistance can manifest as rejection, distortion, or avoidance of new information.
- **Common examples of blocked categories include**
- Prejudice: Preconceived opinions about individuals or groups.
- Stereotypes: Oversimplified generalizations about groups of people.
- Resistance to change: Difficulty adapting to new ideas or technologies.
- Misoneism: A dislike or fear of new things.
- To overcome blocked categories, individuals must cultivate open-mindedness, critical thinking, and a willingness to consider alternative viewpoints.

# CATEGORICAL THINKING

- **Pansophism**, the belief in knowing everything, is a significant communication barrier. Individuals with this mindset often dismiss new information, hindering effective dialogue. Overgeneralization, characterized by the excessive use of absolute terms (all, always, everyone, etc.), exacerbates this issue.
- **To overcome these challenges, communicators should:**
- **Avoid absolutist language:** Use qualifiers to express uncertainty or nuance.
- **Encourage open-mindedness:** Foster a receptive attitude towards new ideas.
- **Active listening:** Fully engage in the communication process.
- **Seek clarification:** Ask questions to ensure understanding.
- **Acknowledge limitations:** Admit when knowledge is incomplete.
- By adopting these practices, individuals can significantly improve their communication effectiveness and build stronger relationships.

# 2. INTERPERSONAL BARRIERS

- Interpersonal barriers occur due to the inappropriate transaction of words between two or more people.
- The two broad categories into which these barriers can be classified are:

1) Inefficient communication skills
2) Negative aspect nurturing in the climate

- ***The most common reasons for interpersonal barriers are:***
- Limited vocabulary
- Incompatibility (clash) of verbal and non-verbal messages
- Emotional outburst
- Communication selectivity
- Cultural variations
- Poor listening skills
- Noise in the channel

# LIMITED VOCABULARY

- **Limited vocabulary hinders effective communication.**
- A strong vocabulary is crucial for expressing ideas clearly. However, simply knowing many words isn't enough; understanding their precise meanings and using them appropriately is key.
- Expanding vocabulary through reading and listening is essential for successful communication.
- (denotative and Connotative meanings)
- Eg. Can you burn it for me? (implied/ suggested)

# INCOMPATIBILITY OF VERBAL AND NON-VERBAL MESSAGES

- Non-verbal communication is as important as verbal communication.
- Conflicting verbal and non-verbal cues can confuse listeners.
- Example: The expression on the person's face shows just the opposite of what they are saying.
- To communicate effectively, match your body language with your words.
- Be aware of cultural differences in non-verbal cues and avoid making assumptions based on appearance.

# EMOTIONAL OUTBURST

- Emotions play a crucial role in communication, but excessive emotional involvement, like extreme anger, can hinder effective dialogue.
- For example, anger can create a charged environment, making rational discussion impossible.
- To foster good communication, it’s essential to sharpen self-awareness, intuition, and empathy.
- Negative reactions, whether hostile or defensive, arise when a message is perceived as a threat, leading to misinterpretations and lowered opinions.
- Maintaining composure, viewing issues objectively, and addressing emotional triggers calmly are key to preventing these reactions.

# COMMUNICATION SELECTIVITY

- **Communication selectivity** occurs when receivers focus only on parts of a message that interest them. This creates a barrier by hindering full comprehension.
- For example, in a company meeting, employees might only focus on information relevant to their department, missing the broader message.

# CULTURAL VARIATIONS

- Cultural and language differences are major obstacles to effective communication in a globalized world.
- Businesses and individuals must adapt to diverse customs, laws, and communication styles to succeed internationally.

# POOR LISTENING SKILLS

- **Effective listening is crucial for successful communication.** Unlike passive hearing, active listening involves focused attention and understanding the speaker's message. Distractions, emotional disturbances, and preoccupation with personal thoughts can hinder this process.
- For instance, a manager who avoids eye contact while a subordinate speaks demonstrates a lack of attentiveness, negatively impacting the professional relationship.
- **To improve communication, it's essential to actively listen and minimize distractions.**

# NOISE IN THE CHANNEL

- Noise disrupts communication. It can be physical (loud sounds), or psychological (distractions).

# 3. Organizational barriers

- Organizational structure impacts communication. Hierarchical structures can hinder information flow, while flatter structures often have better communication networks.
- Effective communication requires minimizing transfer points and encouraging direct interaction between sender and receiver.
- The main organizational barriers are as follows:
- 1. Too many transfer stations
- 2. Fear of superiors
- 3. Negative tendencies
- 4. Use of inappropriate media.
- 5. Information overload

# Too many transfer stations

- Longer communication chains increase the risk of miscommunication.
- Each person involved can unintentionally alter the message, leading to misunderstandings.
- This is why direct communication is often more effective.

# FEAR OF SUPERIORS

- Fear and hierarchy can stifle communication.
- Employees may withhold information or avoid direct communication with superiors due to fear of repercussions.
- Creating an open and trusting environment is crucial for effective communication.
- Encouraging open dialogue and feedback can lead to better problem-solving and innovation.

# NEGATIVE TENDENCIES

- Organizations often form work groups for specific tasks or recreational purposes. These groups, whether formal or informal, usually consist of people with shared values and beliefs. However, communication barriers can arise when conflicts occur between group members and non-members.
- For instance, student members of a sports club might clash with non-members who oppose increased funding for sports equipment. This insider–outsider dynamic can lead to negative tendencies within the organization, creating communication noise and disrupting effective interaction.

# USE OF INAPPROPRIATE MEDIA

- Choosing the right communication medium is crucial. Factors like time, cost, message type, and audience influence the choice.
- Different media have advantages and limitations. For example, phones are unsuitable for confidential information, while printed letters offer permanence.
- Often, a combination of media is most effective.

# INFORMATION OVERLOAD

- Information overload is a significant communication challenge. Too much information can overwhelm recipients, leading to disinterest and missed critical details.
- To combat this, organizations must prioritize information and target specific audiences.